▼ VIEWPOINT

MODI STRIKES A BALANCE AT TIANJIN

Modi, Putin and Xi meeting in China caused tremors in the West, but there's no reason to expect a breakthrough in ties

BY ASHOK K. KANTHA

A visual emerging from the recent summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) in Tianjin, China, has gone viral. It shows Prime Minister Narendra Modi, President Vladimir Putin and President Xi Jinping in a relaxed moment. Some have interpreted it as an indication of an evolving strategic realignment, bringing India, Russia and China together.

Modi's decision to travel to China after a gap of seven years to attend the SCO summit, and his bilateral engagements with Russian and Chinese leaders reflected an ongoing recalibration in India's foreign policy amidst the backdrop of geopolitical turbulence. But any notion of India making common cause with China, either bilaterally or along with Russia, to deal with the current strain in its strategic partnership with the United States, will be a misreading of its diplomatic stance. India's relations with China and Russia will continue to be driven largely by bilateral considerations, though influenced by pulls and pressures of the larger global landscape.

Modi's attendance symbolised a pragmatic engagement with a platform that balances New Delhi's strategic autonomy. Tianjin no doubt gave China a stage to showcase its convening power, with leaders of 20 countries present, project itself as a factor of stability, and articulate alternatives to US-led institutions, with India positioning itself as a bridge-builder rather than a bloc-joiner. India managed to get a categorical condemnation of the terrorist outrage in Pahalgam in the SCO outcome document, but that was balanced with similar language on violent incidents in Pakistan.

Modi's meeting with Xi has consolidated the process of rebuilding bilateral ties that commenced when the two leaders met in Kazan last October. India signalled that its outreach to China was not a kneejerk reaction to its current US predicament, with Modi telling the Chinese leader that bilateral ties "should not be seen through a third country lens". China sees a period of vulnerability for India which it would like to use for concessions on issues like Taiwan and to project a common front against "unilateral bullying" by the US, but New Delhi has wisely resisted such pressures.

Illustration by RAJ VERMA

THE SUMMIT WAS HARDLY A CHALLENGE TO WESTERN DOMINANCE, AS INDIA'S TIES WITH RUSSIA AND CHINA ARE LARGELY UNCHANGED

The focus since Kazan has been on the resumption of people-centric contacts, with greater economic engagement added to the mix. But the resurrection of the construct of India and China being "development partners and not rivals" sits oddly with divergent strategic outlooks and Beijing's reluctance to move beyond tactical posturing to accommodate India as a co-ascendant nation. China is unlikely to have accepted such a formulation had India adopted a stance like China's operational support to Pakistan during Op. Sindoor, for example.

India and China's differences on the border issue also surfaced in Tianjin. Modi "underlined the importance of peace and tranquility on the border areas for continued development of bilateral relations", but Xi maintained that the two countries must "not let the border issue define the overall China-India relationship". India has agreed to explore the previously rejected Chinese proposal on "early harvest" in boundary negotiations. Indian negotiators will have to exercise caution and eschew any temptation to show contrived progress, yielding on substance. In de-escalation talks, India's disadvantages in terms of terrain, border infrastructure and the time taken to induct troops will have to be factored in, as agreed in 1996.

With Russia, engagements in Tianjin explicitly signalled there would be no dilution of bilateral strategic ties or procurements in defence and energy sectors under western pressures.

The signals and optics from Tianjin resonated strongly in the US and West, portraying the SCO as a challenge to western dominance. The reality is more mundane and hardly conveyed a marked shift toward multipolarity and a "reverse Nixon" strategy where non-western powers coalesce. At the bilateral level, there was some acceleration of the progress towards normalisation of ties with China, without yielding breakthroughs. ■

The author is a former Ambassador to China